

Reading and Writing Research Reports

Reporting research results has a few basic components:

1. What has the author(s) read that prompted the research?
2. What is the purpose of the research being reported?
3. What is the specific research question or research hypothesis?
4. How was the research conducted?
 - a) who were the participants?
 - b) what equipment and/or materials were used?
 - c) what treatment & data collection procedures were used?
5. What are the results of the statistical analysis of the data as ...they relate to the research question or research hypothesis?
6. How do the current findings integrate with what the author(s) read that prompted the research?

All of our discussions about reading or writing research reports will revolve around these 6 things. (Learn 'em!!!)

Parts of an APA Paper

One way to describe how the content of an APA paper is arranged is to consider the basic parts, and then to look at which parts contain the 6 components of a research report.

- **Title page** -- the title should capture the intent/results of the study
- **Abstract** -- 250 word (max) summary of the key info of a study
- **Introduction** -- review of the literature that prompted the research
- **Method**

- **Participants** -- who (what) and how they were selected
- **Materials** -- equipment and materials used to collect data
- **Procedure** -- treatment and data collection details
- **Results** -- description of the data analysis and results
- **Discussion** -- relating the findings to the previous literature
- **References** -- citations of previous literature referred to in report
- **Tables, Figures, Etc.** -- usually used to present data & analyses

Standardizing Research Reports

Since there is a nearly universal set of 6 things used to describe one's research and its outcomes, it makes sense to "standardize" those reports -- making it easier to write them clearly and easier to read them.

Such "standardization" was the intent of a group of editors and business managers of anthropological and psychological journals in 1928. They wrote a 7-page set of guidelines for authors. The most recent version of these guidelines, the *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association, 7th Ed.*, is a bit larger (427 pages), but has the same basic intent. We are getting better at streamlining the "rules" in the recent edition.

APA format, as we will apply it, has three components:

1. the content of the report and how it is organized and labeled
2. the format of the report (e.g., margins, citations, tables, etc.)
3. the style of the report (e.g., non-sexist language)

Where to look for the information to critique a research report??

1) What has the author(s) read that prompted the research?

Introduction, Discussion, References

2) What is the purpose of the research being reported?

Abstract, Introduction, Discussion

3) What is the specific research question or research hypothesis?

Abstract, Introduction, Results, Discussion

4) How was the research conducted?

a) who were the participants?

Abstract, Method - Participants

b) what equipment and/or materials were used?

Abstract, Method - Materials/Apparatus

c) what treatment & data collection procedures were used?

Abstract, Method - Procedures

5) What are the results of the statistical analysis of the data as ...they relate to the research question or research hypothesis?

Abstract, Results, Discussion, Tables/Figures

6) How do the current findings integrate with what the author(s) read that prompted the research?

Abstract, Discussion

It is a good idea to check each area of the paper for the different kinds of information. In particular, don't depend on the Abstract's very brief descriptions of the different components of the report.

If the Abstract were a sufficient portrayal of the research, we wouldn't have to write the other 10-30 pages!!

Elements of APA format & style you'll need for your first writing assignment ...

Start with a few basic rules:

- Double-space everything
- Have uniform margins of at least 1 in. at the top, bottom, right, and left of every page
- Write "formally" -- without slang, contractions, etc.
- Use sentences and paragraphs -- do not "list" information
 - We want to write with some "flow" but we don't want to be overly wordy as we avoid being "listy" -- find the happy medium
- Give credit to others for their ideas -- if you found a good idea in an article cite that article when you use the idea BUT paraphrase the original words -- this does not mean swap in synonyms, that is still plagiarizing!